

American Political Divides and Great Debates

[84-309] | Fall 2026

Prof. Jonathan Cervas

Updated: September 10, 2026

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The most up-to-date version of this **syllabus** can be found [here](#).

Course Relevance: DC: Perspectives on Justice and Injustice
Learning Resources: All resources will be provided via Canvas
Prerequisites: NONE

August	September	October	November	December
S M T W T F S	S M T W T F S	S M T W T F S	S M T W T F S	S M T W T F S
1	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3	1 2 3 4 5 6 7	1 2 3 4 5
2 3 4 5 6 7 8	6 7 8 9 10 11 12	4 5 6 7 8 9 10	8 9 10 11 12 13 14	6 7 8 9 10 11 12
9 10 11 12 13 14 15	13 14 15 16 17 18 19	11 12 13 14 15 16 17	15 16 17 18 19 20 21	13 14 15 16 17 18 19
16 17 18 19 20 21 22	20 21 22 23 24 25 26	18 19 20 21 22 23 24	22 23 24 25 26 27 28	20 21 22 23 24 25 26
23 24 25 26 27 28 29	27 28 29 30	25 26 27 28 29 30 31	29 30	27 28 29 30 31
30 31				
in person	remote	no class		

Why are Americans so divided — and is the premise even true? We spend a month on what political science actually knows, then the semester is yours: student teams pick the topics, assign the readings, and run the room.

01 Assessment

The course grade will be a weighted average of the following components:

Assignment	Percent of Final Grade
Attendance	25%
Discussion Board (before each class)	15%
Student Led Topics	9%
Surveys (3: intake, midterm, evaluation)	2%
Book Review (Slides + Presentation)	12%
Op-Ed Project (Draft + Review + Final)	20%
Group Policy Brief	17%

02 Due Dates

Assignment	Due Date
Discussion board post	9:00 a.m., each class day
Surveys (3)	August 26, October 7, final week
Op-ed topic, on the board	September 15 (subject), 17 (replies)
Op-ed, first draft	September 21
Op-ed peer review	September 24
Op-ed final draft	September 28
Book Review (slides)	November 23
Group Project	December 1/3
Group Project reflection	December 4

03 The Essentials

- **Before every class:** one short discussion-board post, due **9:00 a.m.**, in Canvas. Two more fall in the no-class week of **September 15**, where the class settles op-ed subjects.
- **Attendance is 25%.** The first three absences cost almost nothing; four to six is where a semester goes wrong.
- **Late work** costs one point per hour, but never drops below 50% — with one exception: the **op-ed rough draft (September 21)** loses 10% imme-

diately, then 1% per hour, with no floor and no exceptions, because two classmates are waiting on it.

- **Devices stay in bags.** Non-class use of a laptop or phone means being marked absent for that session.
- **Surveys** and their screenshot receipts run through **Canvas, under Assignments.**

04 The Full Syllabus

Everything else — the week-by-week schedule with all readings, assignment details, and every policy — lives in the full syllabus:

<https://jcervas.github.io/teaching/2026-2027/class-cmu-2026-84-309/readme.html>